



A GAME ABOUT MAKING HISTORY

— RULEBOOK —

1 – 5 PLAYERS · 45 – 90 MINUTES · AGES 16+

Designed by David Stephen Bennett

Play a free digital version at game.thehistorians.org

WELCOME TO THE PROFESSION

Congratulations, Doctor — welcome to the guild. You've just started a one-year appointment at a prestigious university. Your office is beautiful: large wooden desk, centuries-old oaks, ivy climbing the buildings out the window.

You are hungry for more: the Pulitzer, a name that outlives you. Will you hire a literary agent, court a publicist, or pour everything into research funding and archive visits? It all serves the same goals. Writing the story of the past. Publishing the next great argument.

I OVERVIEW & GOAL

Your goal is **prestige**. The historian with the most prestige at game's end has had the most distinguished career. Earn it by **publishing manuscripts**, being **cited** by rivals, attending **conferences**, and winning **end-of-game awards**.

Play solo, or with up to five players. The **solo** version uses the card-tag system to judge your manuscripts; in the **multiplayer** version, you must persuade the other players to approve them.

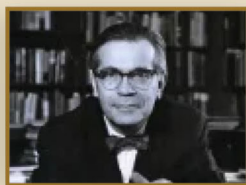
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WHICH HISTORIAN WILL YOU BE?



Mary Ritter Beard
(1876 – 1958)



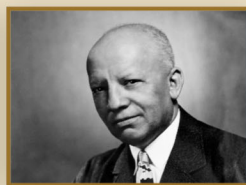
Richard Hofstadter
(1916 – 1970)



Gerda Lerner
(1920 – 2013)



Letitia Woods Brown
(1915 – 1976)



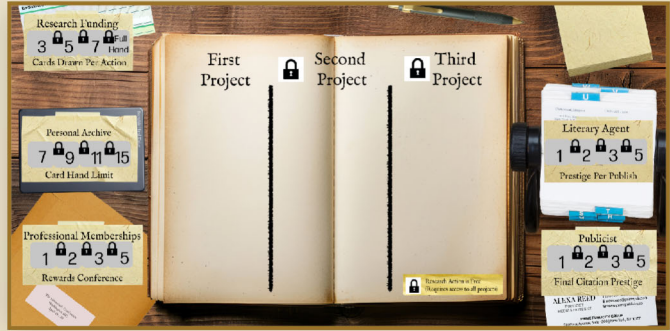
Carter G. Woodson
(1875 – 1950)

2 COMPONENTS

QUANTITY	COMPONENT
1	Archive Board — Shared prestige track, archive stacks
5	Offices — Player mats that each player should keep
30 per color	Citation Tokens — Translucent acrylic asterisks, five colors
6 per color	Upgrade Markers — Translucent acrylic, five colors
150 – 250 cards (varies)	Archive Decks — American Revolution, Montgomery Bus Boycott, or Early / Middle / Late Cold War
24 per player	Conclusion Cards — 12 article and 12 book theses per color



The Archive Board. A 100-space prestige track beside four archive stacks to be placed within reach of all players.

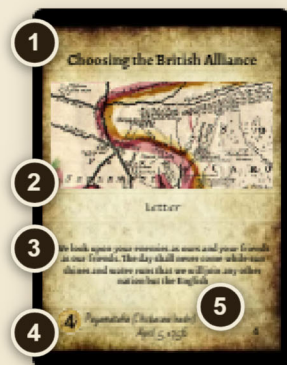


Offices. A playmat which keeps track of your five stat upgrades, three project workspaces, and citation tokens.

CITATION TOKENS. Acrylic counters placed in the middle of the playspace. Every time you gain a **citation token**, you will place that citation on the sticky tabs located on the top right of your playmat.

2 THE CARDS

Evidence cards represent real primary **sources**. The front of the card shows information from the source itself and only the **writer** reads it. The back shows the sorting tags of the cards. Only **reviewers** see this information.



Face



Back

1 Title / Research Question

2 Context Terms

3 Verbatim quote or context description

4 Prestige value

5 Author

6 Sorting tags — the arguments this card supports

7 Historical significance

8 Citation of the real source

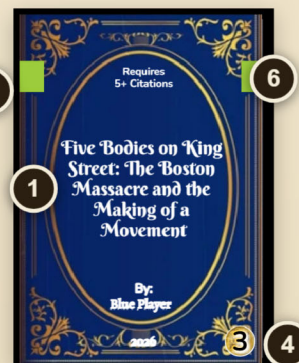
Conclusion cards represent your thesis statement. When you build an argument, you'll select cards to support your research question. Players may select cards based on the themes they see in the evidence, the sorting tags, and prestige value. When a **manuscript** is **published**, the **conclusion card** becomes the cover of the publication.



Thesis face



Published article



Published book

3 SETUP

1. Pick an **archive** deck. Shuffle it, divide it into four equal stacks, and place them on the **archive board**.
2. Pick a game length — Short (8 years), Medium (11), or Long (15). **Solo** is always 25 years.
3. Give each player a playmat and their **conclusion** deck. Set every stat to level 1; only the first **workspace** is open.
4. Each player draws 3 **evidence** cards.
5. Set the year counter to **Year 1**; everyone starts at 0 **prestige**.
6. Randomly choose a first player.

4 THE YEAR

Every round is a year. Each year runs through up to four phases, then the next year begins:

I · UPGRADE — During this phase, writers attend a **conference** or successfully **publish** a **manuscript**.

II · ACTION — In turn order, each player takes one action (see p. 6).

III · PEER REVIEW — Reviewers deliver verdicts on any **manuscripts** put up for publication (see p. 8). This phase is skipped if nobody published.

IV · CONFERENCE — Attendees resolve the **conference pool** (p. 9). This is skipped if nobody attended.



A plan of Boston and its harbour, 1775 — the road to Concord, the late engagement between the King's troops and the provincials, and both armies' encampments, taken from an actual survey.

5 ACTIONS

Each year you take one action: **Research**, **Publish a Manuscript**, or **Attend a Conference** (see p. 9).

RESEARCH

Draw **evidence** cards from the **archive** equal to your **Research Funding** rank (3 / 5 / 7 / up to hand limit). Each time a card is taken, a new card is revealed in its place. You can never draw beyond the **Personal Archive** hand limit shown on your playmat.

PUBLISH A MANUSCRIPT

Adding **evidence** or a **conclusion** to an unlocked **workspace** is free at any time. When you submit your **manuscript**, you can supplement your evidence with any already published works, and then submit the manuscript to **peer review**. To submit a **manuscript**, it needs to contain the following:

ARTICLE

1 **conclusion** + 2 or more **sources**.

BOOK

1 **conclusion** + 5 or more **sources**.

After you compile your **manuscript** with its relevant **sources**, you must now wait for the **peer review** phase, where your **manuscript** is reviewed to see if it is a valid argument (see p. 8).

ATTEND A CONFERENCE

Choose a number of evidence cards from your hand equal to your **Professional Memberships** rank and add them to the **conference** pool. Then wait — the conference resolves during the Conference phase at the end of the year (see p. 9).

WHAT DRIVES A HIGH SCORE? Rare evidence (higher printed prestige), a focused argument (shared context doubles the total), and your **Literary Agent** rank (a per-card bonus).

6 YOUR OFFICE

Grants and rewards let you **upgrade** six stats, each from level 1 to 4. **Upgrades** come during the **Upgrade** phase in even years and when your career reaches milestones. Specialize — no historian can master everything.

STAT	EFFECT	LV 1	LV 2	LV 3	LV 4
Research Funding	Cards drawn per Research	3	5	7	Hand limit
Personal Archive	Hand limit	7	9	11	15
Literary Agent	Prestige per card on acceptance	0	1	2	4
Workspaces	Open project slots	First	Second	Third	Publish is free
Prof. Memberships	Conference draws & tokens; higher rank drafts first	1	2	3	5
Publicist	Prestige per citation token at game end	1	2	3	4

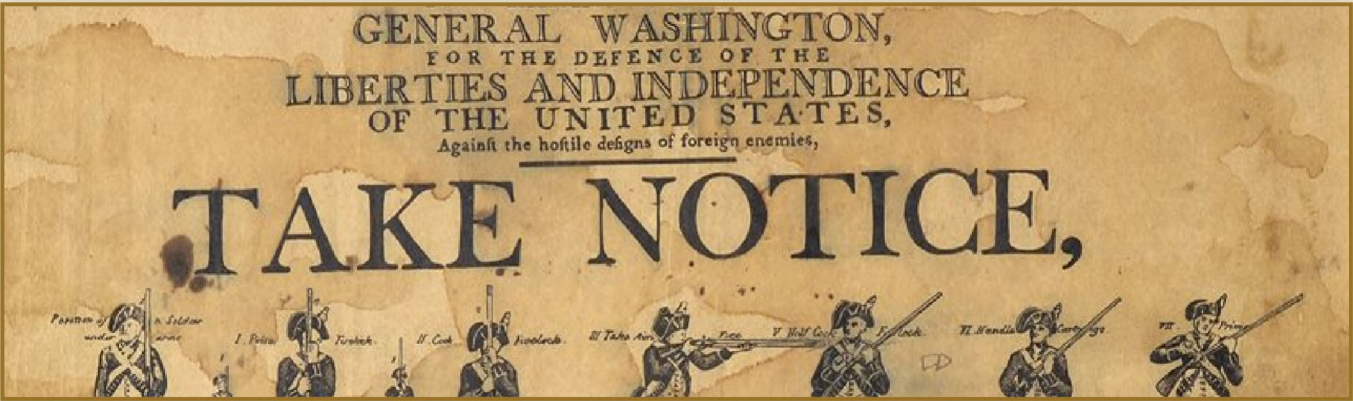
CAREER MILESTONES

- 1+ prestige** Visiting Assistant Professor
- 1 manuscript** Assistant Professor (Tenure Track)
- 1 book** Associate Professor (Tenured)
- 3 books** Full Professor
- 6 books** Endowed Professor

ADVANCED VARIANT

End of **year 3**: any player with no publication loses 5 prestige each year until they publish.

End of **year 5**: any player with no book loses 5 prestige each year until they publish one.



Recruitment poster for George Washington's Continental Army

7 PEER REVIEW

IF any player has submitted a manuscript, follow the peer review phase process:

SOLO. Flip your cards and read the backs. If one **tag** is shared by every card, the **manuscript** is **Approved** — score it. Otherwise it is **Rejected** and you will need to make the necessary changes to the publication and republish it to get a successful score. Solo games skip **Revise & Resubmit**.

MULTIPLAYER. Present the backs of your cards to the reviewers and pitch your argument; they may question your evidence. You see everything on your side — they see only **tags**, significance, and **citations**. Bluffing is possible, but it has a price. The verdict is by majority; ties become **Revise & Resubmit**.

OUTCOMES

Approve → Publish the manuscript. Score it, discard the evidence, flip the **conclusion** face-up on your desk where others may **cite** it.

R & R → (**Multiplayer only**) The reviewer flags **evidence** the writer must discard in order for the **manuscript** to be published. The writer can choose to accept the changes and publish, securing an upgrade and gaining prestige for the publication, while the reviewer gains five prestige. The writer may choose to file an **objection** to the reviewer's findings.

Reject → (**Solo only**) The writer learns which evidence cards do not work with the overall argument, and all evidence is reclaimed. The writer must **publish** the **manuscript** again as a new action.

Object → After receiving an R&R, the writer flips the cards over and checks **tags** per the **solo** rules. If they match, the work is **Accepted** and every reviewer who rejected the article loses 5 prestige. If the tags do not match, the manuscript is **Rejected** and the **writer** loses 5 prestige. Academic trust cuts both ways.



Paul Revere's "Bloody Massacre," 1770

CITATION TAG RULE. If your manuscript cites published works, cited publications work similarly, comparing the book's **tags** to the other **evidence** cards.

SCORING AN ACCEPTED MANUSCRIPT

1. Add the prestige values of every card, including cited published manuscripts, plus your **Literary Agent** bonus per card.
2. Double it if every evidence card shares one common context field — context tag, source type, location, or author.
3. Flip the conclusion to its published face, name your work, and discard the evidence. Others may now cite it.

8 CONFERENCES

IF any player has chosen to attend a conference, you follow this conference phase process:

1. Draw a number of cards from the archive equal to the number of players and add them to the **conference pool**.
2. In **Professional Membership** rank order, players draft cards from the **conference pool** equal to their Membership ranks.
3. After all cards have been drafted by all players, each player takes one leftover card and places it in front of their office, representing their **conference publication**, and then they place **citation tokens** equal to their **professional membership** on the new publication.
4. All players **upgrade** their personal space once.

9 CITATIONS

When you cite a colleague's published work inside your own argument:

- The **writer** gains **prestige** equal to **conclusion card** being **cited**
- The **reviewer** gains 1 **citation token** from the writer and added to the publication's conclusion card. You may use your own work in future arguments, but you do not gain citation tokens.

At game end, each token is worth prestige equal to your **Publicist** rank (1 / 2 / 3 / 4). The Publicist is the lever that turns influence into victory.

SAMPLE ARGUMENT FOR PEER REVIEW

"Boycotts were foundational to the Revolution: New York, Philadelphia, and Boston merchants answered taxation with boycotts."

CARD	CONTEXT BONUS TAGS		
Was the war about profits? (<i>conclusion</i>)	—	+4	Economic
Boycotts Cut British Trade	Boycotts	+3	Econ, Colonial
Merchants Refuse British Goods	Boycotts	+3	Econ, Colonial
Boston Halts British Imports	Boycotts	+3	Econ, Colonial

1. Valid? Every card shares the Economic tag → reviewers should approve.
2. **Article or book?** Three evidence cards → an article (a book needs 5+).
3. Base prestige: 4 + 3 + 3 + 3 = **13**.
4. Double? All evidence shares the Boycotts context → 13 becomes **26**.

See the fanned-out cards of this example on p. 10.

10 END OF GAME

When the final year passes, scoring resolves in three steps: ① **prestige** earned during the game, plus ② **citation** tokens × **Publicist** rank, plus ③ **awards**. Ties share awards at full value; an award nobody qualifies for is not given. Most prestige wins — break ties by most awards, then by the Lifetime Achievement Award.

AWARD	POINTS	HOW TO WIN
Francis Perkins Award	15	The single publication built on the most evidence
Lifetime Achievement	15	The most publications, articles and books combined
Renaissance Scholar	10	Publications across the most distinct conclusions
The Pulitzer Award	10	The most citations — must have published at least once
Prodigy	10	First to publish a book



What the writer sees.



What the reviewers see.

GLOSSARY A – O

Approved. (pp. 2, 8, 9) This is a peer-review verdict that allows a manuscript to be scored immediately and sent to the bookshelf, allowing the writer to receive an upgrade.

Archive (Board · Deck · Evidence). (pp. 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10) The shared board at the center of the table, holding the prestige track and four stacks of evidence cards that represent the archive decks created at the start of the game.

Article. (pp. 3, 4, 6, 8, 9, 10) A publication that represents an accepted manuscript that had one conclusion and two to four evidence cards.

Attend a Conference. (pp. 2, 5, 6, 9) The action of joining a conference, which will trigger the conference phase. This action allows you to remove less useful cards from your hand in order to add more useful cards to your hand. This action also provides you with a one-card publication that can be cited by other players in the future, plus additional citation tokens that will be scored at the end of the game.

Book. (pp. 3, 4, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10) A publication that represents an accepted manuscript that had one conclusion and five or more evidence cards.

Citation (Cite · Tokens). (pp. 2, 3, 4, 7, 8, 9, 10) This is the act of using an already published work as evidence within your own manuscript. When you do this, you place one of the unused citation markers in your player color on the player's published manuscript (conference paper, article, or book). At the end of the game, all of the citation markers each player has achieved will be worth prestige equal to its owner's rank in Publicist.

Conclusion Card. (pp. 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9, 10) A thesis card carrying a research question, sorting tags, and a prestige value. There are two types of conclusion cards, articles and books. When published, the writer discards all of the evidence used in the manuscript and flips the conclusion card over to represent his publication.

Conference (Card Pool · Attend). (pp. 2, 5, 6, 7, 9) The fourth phase of the year is called the Conference phase. If at least one player has taken the "attend the conference" action, then a number of cards from the archive decks are added to the conference pool of cards and the conference phase is resolved. This phase allows players to draw new cards into their hand from the conference pool, secure a one-card publication, and gain citations equal to their Professional Membership stat.

Context Field. (pp. 4, 6, 9) This is a field represented on the cards that helps the player understand the historical context of the primary source. It often includes data like the location, source type, or relevant historical events. When a manuscript is scored, the writer checks all the evidence cards in the publication to see if they all share one similar context field, and if so the score doubles.

End of Game Awards. (pp. 2, 10) There are five awards that are scored at the end of the game worth either 10 or 15 prestige (p. 10).

Literary Agent. (pp. 2, 6, 7, 9) This is a player stat tracked in their office that offers bonus prestige per card whenever a manuscript is scored.

Manuscript. (pp. 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9) This is a collection of cards that includes one conclusion card and a number of source cards (evidence and previous publications) that have been submitted for peer review. Accepted manuscripts become publications.

Multiplayer. (pp. 2, 8) This is a game mode where two to five historians may play the game. During this mode, players will act as peer reviewers for each publication.

Objection. (p. 8) (Multiplayer Mode Only) This is a free action a player can take after the peer reviewers decide a manuscript must be revised before it can be published. It allows a player who believes in his work to circumvent the opposing player peer review process and reveal the tags for themselves, but it comes with additional penalties for the players who were wrong.

Office (Bookshelf). (pp. 3, 9) This is the playmat that all players get that keeps track of your five player stats, your workspaces, and your citations. The bookshelf is the space on the play surface right above your office where you store any published manuscripts.

Peer Review. (pp. 2, 5, 6, 8) (Multiplayer Mode Only) This is the third phase in the year that is triggered when at least one player published a manuscript. During this phase, peer reviewers hear the argument, review the tags and then issue a verdict of Approve, or Revise & Resubmit. It is also the phase of the game where the writer may score prestige and accept office upgrades for accepted verdicts, or even take the Objection free action for Revise & Resubmit verdicts.

Personal Archive. (pp. 6, 7) This is a player stat tracked in their office that increases your hand limit (7 / 9 / 11 / 15).

Prestige. (pp. 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10) This is the term in the game used to refer to victory points, allowing players to determine who wins the game. The historian with the most prestige at retirement wins.

Professional Memberships. (pp. 6, 7, 9) This is a player stat tracked in their office that affects how beneficial the Attend a Conference action is. It modifies the order in which you draw cards from the conference, how many cards you add to the conference pool, and how many cards you draw from the conference pool.

Publicist. (pp. 2, 7, 9, 10) This is a player stat tracked in their office that improves the amount of prestige earned for each citation token at game end (1 / 2 / 3 / 4).

Publish. (pp. 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10) This is the action of submitting a manuscript from a workspace for peer review.

Rejected. (p. 8) This is a peer-review verdict that is the result of a writer revealing the tags on the back of sources during the peer review stage. In Multiplayer mode, this verdict will force the writer to lose 5 prestige points.

Research. (pp. 2, 4, 6, 7) This is the action of drawing evidence cards up to the player's Research Funding rank from any of the Archive Decks on the Archive Board.

Research Funding. (pp. 2, 6, 7) This is a player stat tracked in their office that modifies how many cards are drawn from the archive deck for every Research action (3 / 5 / 7 / hand limit).

Revise & Resubmit. (p. 8) This is a peer-review verdict that has the reviewer flagging any source cards that do not work with the conclusion card and asking the writer to drop those cards from the manuscript. The writer is then tasked with choosing whether they accept the verdict or issue an Objection.

Solo. (pp. 2, 5, 8) This is a one-player game mode where the player relies on only the Approve and Reject verdict options during the peer-review phase.

Sources. (pp. 4, 6, 9) These are represented by any cards used in a manuscript. They can include the evidence cards that make up either the archive decks or the previously published cards found on other players' bookshelves.

Tag. (pp. 2, 4, 8, 9) This is a unique tagging system located on the back of source cards that indicates which conclusions the card supports. A valid argument shares one tag across every card.

Upgrade (Phase · Markers). (pp. 3, 5, 7, 8, 9) This is a phase of the game which occurs at the end of the year if any player has either successfully published a manuscript or attended a conference. This phase allows the player(s) who trigger it to raise one stat to its next level. These upgrades are tracked in the player's office.

Workspaces. (pp. 3, 5, 6, 7) This is a player stat tracked in their office that modifies how many project slots each player can use to store evidence cards from their notebook while building manuscripts. After a player has unlocked all three project workspaces, the player can upgrade his publish action to not cost an action to perform.

Writer. (pp. 4, 5, 8, 9, 10) This is the player who has compiled sources into a manuscript for peer review.

Year. (pp. 2, 5, 6, 7, 10) This is exactly one round of play for all players, that includes up to four phases: Action, Peer Review, Conference, and Upgrade.

QUICK REFERENCE

THE YEAR

- I **Upgrade** — even years: upgrade one stat
- II **Action** — one action each, in turn order
- III **Peer Review** — verdicts on submissions
- IV **Conference** — attendees resolve the pool

ACTIONS — PICK ONE

- Research** — draw cards = Research Funding
- Publish** — submit a workspace for review
- Conference** — add cards = Memberships rank to the pool

PUBLISHING CHECKLIST

- ☐ 1 conclusion + 2 evidence (article) / 5 (book)
- ☐ One tag shared by every card
- ☐ Cited works match the conclusion's tag
- ☐ Shared context field? Score doubles

SCORING A MANUSCRIPT

Sum all card prestige + Literary Agent bonus per card + $\frac{1}{2}$ of each cited conclusion. Double the total if all evidence shares one context field.

VERDICTS

- Approve** — publish & score
- R & R** — accept the reviewer's cuts (reviewer +5), or object
- Reject** (solo) — revise & publish again
- Object** — check tags: wrong rejecter -5, or writer -5

END OF GAME

- Prestige earned
- + citation tokens $\times$ Publicist rank
- + awards (15/15/10/10/10)
- Ties: most awards, then Lifetime Achievement